Free OpenAI ChatGPT API Key: How to Get and Use Your API Key

API Key · How to Use | Updated October 28, 2026

A **free OpenAI ChatGPT API key** can help developers connect OpenAI's AI capabilities with websites, applications, scripts, chatbots, and other software projects. If you are looking for a free OpenAI ChatGPT API key, the safest approach is to create your own API credential through the official OpenAI API platform and then use it from your application. The API key is used to authenticate requests, while ChatGPT itself is the interactive AI product that users access through the ChatGPT interface.

It is also important to understand how **ChatGPT and OpenAI API access** work together. OpenAI currently maintains separate billing systems for ChatGPT and the API platform. A ChatGPT plan and API usage are therefore managed independently.

For someone starting an AI project, this distinction makes the whole process much easier to understand. You can use ChatGPT for direct conversations and use an OpenAI API key when you want your own application to communicate with OpenAI models.

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What Is a Free OpenAI ChatGPT API Key?

The phrase **free OpenAI ChatGPT API key** is widely searched by people who want to experiment with OpenAI technology from their own applications.

An API key is essentially a credential that allows your application to authenticate with the OpenAI API. Instead of opening ChatGPT manually and entering a prompt, your software can send a request to an OpenAI API and process the response automatically.

The word **free** in a search such as "free OpenAI ChatGPT API key" should be understood in terms of whatever free usage, credits, promotions, or account eligibility OpenAI currently provides. The API key itself is the authentication credential; it does not automatically represent unlimited free API usage.

ChatGPT and OpenAI API Are Two Different Ways to Use AI

ChatGPT is a ready-to-use application. You open ChatGPT, type a question, and receive an answer through the ChatGPT interface.

The OpenAI API is designed for developers. It allows software applications to send requests to OpenAI models and use the resulting responses inside another product.

For example:

ChatGPT: You → ChatGPT interface → AI response

OpenAI API: Your application → OpenAI API → AI model → Your application

OpenAI confirms that ChatGPT and API platform billing are handled separately.

How to Get a Free OpenAI ChatGPT API Key

1. Sign In to OpenAI — Start by signing in to your OpenAI account.

2. Open the API Platform — After signing in, access the OpenAI API platform.

3. Open the API Key Section — Go to the API key management page. OpenAI's current documentation says that users can create, manage, and delete API keys from the API key page.

4. Create a New Secret Key — Choose the option to create a new secret key. You may be able to give the key a name that identifies its purpose.

5. Save the Key Immediately — When you create a secret API key, save it securely. OpenAI states that the full secret key is shown when it is created.

Where Do You Find an OpenAI API Key?

Your OpenAI API keys are managed through the API key page.

The official OpenAI Help Center explains that users can create, manage, and delete API keys from this page. It also explains that the full secret key is available when the key is initially created.

If you have already created a key and saved it somewhere secure, use that stored value in your application.

If the original secret value has been lost, creating a replacement key is the appropriate approach.

How to Use a Free OpenAI API Key

Once you have your API key, you can connect it to an application that supports OpenAI API requests.

A typical development workflow looks like this:

OpenAI account → API key → secure application configuration → API request → OpenAI model → response

Your application sends a request to the API. The API authenticates the request using your key and processes it according to the model and features selected by your application.

Using an OpenAI ChatGPT API Key in Python

Python is one of the most popular languages for experimenting with AI APIs.

A beginner can create a small Python project that accepts a question, sends it to an OpenAI model, and displays the response.

For security, the API key should be stored outside the main source code.

For example, an environment variable can be named OPENAI_API_KEY.

Your Python application can then read the credential from the environment when it needs to authenticate with OpenAI.

Using a Free OpenAI API Key With JavaScript

For server-side JavaScript applications, developers can use the appropriate OpenAI SDK or make API requests from their backend.

A secure website architecture generally looks like this:

Browser → Your website server → OpenAI API

The browser communicates with your server. Your server communicates with OpenAI using the secret API key.

Putting a secret OpenAI API key directly into frontend JavaScript can expose it to anyone who inspects the website.

Free OpenAI API Key for a Website

Website owners can use an OpenAI API key to add AI-powered features to their sites.

For example, you could create an AI FAQ assistant where visitors enter questions and receive answers generated through an OpenAI model.

Another possibility is a writing assistant that helps users generate outlines, rewrite text, summarize information, or create drafts.

The API gives developers flexibility because the AI functionality can be built around the needs of the website rather than relying entirely on the standard ChatGPT interface.

Free ChatGPT OpenAI API Key for a Chatbot

A custom chatbot can be integrated into a website, mobile application, customer-support system, or internal company tool.

The basic process is simple:

A user sends a message. Your application receives the message. Your backend sends the relevant information to an OpenAI model. The model generates a response. Your application displays the response to the user.

With additional programming, developers can add conversation history, custom

instructions, databases, authentication, user accounts, and other application features.

Is a Free OpenAI API Key Really Free?

The API key is a credential that identifies your API access. Whether your account has free API usage, credits, or paid usage depends on the current account configuration and OpenAI's applicable policies.

OpenAI's current billing documentation explains that API usage is managed separately from ChatGPT and that API charges depend on the models and features used, including token usage and applicable tool or storage charges.

Does ChatGPT Free Give You an OpenAI API Key?

Using the ChatGPT Free plan and using the OpenAI API are different experiences.

A ChatGPT account lets you use ChatGPT according to the features and limits of the plan available to your account.

The OpenAI API requires its own API credentials and API account configuration.

OpenAI explicitly states that ChatGPT and API billing are separate.

Does ChatGPT Plus Include OpenAI API Access?

A ChatGPT subscription does not function as a replacement for an API billing account.

OpenAI's billing documentation states that API usage is billed separately from ChatGPT subscriptions.

This is an important point for developers who already pay for ChatGPT and want to use

OpenAI models inside their own applications.

What Can You Do With a Free OpenAI ChatGPT API Key?

AI Writing Tools — An application can generate drafts, summaries, outlines, descriptions, and other text-based content.

Website Chatbots — A website can provide a custom AI assistant that answers questions from visitors.

Coding Assistants — Developers can create tools that explain code, generate examples, or assist with development tasks.

Educational Applications — Students and educators can build applications that explain concepts, generate practice questions, or provide interactive learning experiences.

Automation — API requests can be integrated into automated workflows where text needs to be processed or generated.

Customer Support — Businesses can create AI-assisted support tools that help answer frequently asked questions or organize customer inquiries.

How to Protect Your OpenAI API Key

Keep Your Key Private — Treat your OpenAI API key like a password.

Use Environment Variables — Store the key in an environment variable instead of writing the secret directly into your application source.

Use a Backend — For web applications, make API requests from your server rather

than exposing the key in browser code.

Create Separate Keys for Projects — If you work on several applications, separate credentials can make organization and maintenance easier.

Replace Exposed Keys — If a key becomes public, replace it with a new key.

How to Store an OpenAI API Key

A common setup for developers is an environment variable.

For example: OPENAI_API_KEY=your_secret_key

The actual secret value should remain private.

When using a .env file during development, make sure the file is excluded from public source-control repositories.

For production applications, use the secret-management facilities provided by your hosting platform or cloud environment whenever possible.

Can You Share a Free OpenAI API Key?

Sharing your personal API key is a poor credential-management practice.

OpenAI's official documentation explicitly says not to share API keys.

Instead of sharing one key between several people or applications, create appropriate credentials for the projects that need API access.

What Happens When an API Key Is Deleted?

When an OpenAI API key is deleted, applications relying on that key can stop working.

OpenAI's current documentation states that deleted API keys cannot be used.

If you delete a key accidentally, create a replacement key and update the application configuration.

How to Check OpenAI API Billing

OpenAI provides separate billing controls for API usage.

The API billing area lets users manage API-related billing information and review usage according to their account setup.

For individual and team API customers, OpenAI currently documents prepaid credits or automatic card payments, depending on the billing arrangement.

Free OpenAI API Key and API Credits

The terms **API key** and **API credits** describe different things.

An API key is the credential used for authentication.

API credits represent available usage under a billing or credit system.

Having an API key does not by itself establish how much API usage you can make without charges.

Common Problems With an OpenAI API Key

Invalid API Key — An invalid-key error can occur when the credential is incorrect, expired, deleted, or copied incorrectly.

Billing or Credit Error — An API request can also be affected by your account's current billing or credit status.

Rate Limit Error — API services can apply request and token limits. If an application sends too many requests within a short period, it may need to slow down.

Exposed API Key — If a key has accidentally been published, replace it and remove the exposed credential from the public location.

Frequently Asked Questions

How can I get a free OpenAI ChatGPT API key?

Create or sign in to your OpenAI account, access the API platform, and create a secret API key from the API key management page.

Is there a free ChatGPT API key?

You can create an OpenAI API key through your own account. Whether your account has free API usage or credits depends on the current account conditions and OpenAI's applicable policies.

Is a free OpenAI API key unlimited?

A free API key should not be interpreted as unlimited API access. Usage can depend on account eligibility, available credits, limits, models, and current OpenAI policies.

Is the ChatGPT API the same as the OpenAI API?

"ChatGPT API" is a common search phrase, but developers generally use the OpenAI API platform to integrate OpenAI models into their applications.

Does ChatGPT Free include API access?

ChatGPT and the OpenAI API are separate services from a billing perspective. OpenAI states that their billing systems are separate.

Does ChatGPT Plus include free API credits?

ChatGPT subscription billing and API billing are separate.

Where do I create an OpenAI API key?

OpenAI API keys can be created and managed from the API key page.

Can I use an OpenAI API key for a website?

Yes. Developers can integrate the OpenAI API into websites and web applications. The secret key should be stored on the server rather than exposed in frontend code.

Can I use the same OpenAI API key for multiple projects?

It may be technically possible depending on your setup, but separate keys can make project-level credential management easier.

What if I lose my OpenAI API key?

OpenAI states that the full secret key is shown when it is created. If you lose it, create a new key and update your application.

Can I share my OpenAI API key?

OpenAI advises users not to share their API keys.

What should I do if my OpenAI API key is exposed?

Replace the exposed credential with a new key and remove the secret from any public source where it was published.

Can I use an OpenAI API key with Python?

Yes. Python can be used to build applications that communicate with the OpenAI API. Store the API key securely through an environment variable or another secrets-management method.

Can I use an OpenAI API key with JavaScript?
Yes. Server-side JavaScript applications can communicate with the OpenAI API. Keep the secret credential on the backend when building browser-based applications.

Are API credits and an API key the same thing?
No. The API key is an authentication credential, while API credits represent available usage under the applicable billing system.

Conclusion

A **free OpenAI ChatGPT API key** gives developers a way to begin working with OpenAI's API from their own applications. The key provides authentication for API requests, while the actual amount of free or paid usage depends on the account, current credits, applicable limits, and OpenAI's current policies.

The best starting point is to create your own API key through the official OpenAI API platform. Keep the credential private, save it securely when it is created, and use environment variables or a suitable secrets manager when connecting it to your application.

It is equally important to remember that **ChatGPT and the OpenAI API are separate from a billing perspective**. ChatGPT is designed for direct AI conversations, while the API is designed for developers building AI functionality into software.

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